

Indian Auction Indicator



Source: ArtTactic

"In that sense, it's a good thing," says Veronica Collins, specialist, contemporary art at London art house Philips de Pury & Company, "Now a lot more attention is being paid to the art bought. It's a return to connoisseurship." Adds Maithili Parekh, deputy director at Sotheby's India, "Despite the slowdown, top quality art in good condition with stellar provenance is still sought after." So for those with the money, it's also a great time to buy. Given its cyclical nature, prices will bounce back once markets recover. Amit Vadehra, partner, Crayon Capital is optimistic, "We are in touch with several buyers who are eagerly looking at buying high quality art. I am confident we will still see good results and prices, regardless of the economic environment."

"Most people just look at the highs" says Tuli. "The key

test of an artwork is what is the threshold below which it will not fall irrespective of the circumstances?" As Sonal Singh, specialist at Christie's says, "If you choose high quality pieces, you know that they will not lose value but if you buy indiscriminately, you cannot be sure." Moreover, says Roshini Vadehra, director Vadehra Art Gallery: "There is a regained confidence in the modern Indian art market, which has always been supported by domestic buyers. It is holding up better than the contemporary, as buyers are looking for established artists with proven historical value. Contemporary art was being hugely driven by Western collectors or investors who are no longer supporting the market."

Yet there are no hard and fast rules. While the works of masters—the likes of Husain, S.H. Raza, Souza, Akbar Padamsee, V.S. Gaitonde—are relatively risk-free investments, works depend on the year in which the paintings were made. For instance, some of the best years for the artists, according to experts, are 1955-65 for Souza, the '90s for Mehta, while Husain's golden years are considered the '70s-'80s. Outside these years, the prices of the artists' works may fluctuate significantly and are not considered great investments. One must also keep in mind the resale value of art, which in the present market, says Roshini, is not as successful. "Most collectors are looking for low prices

or a bargain with a work. Unless it's a distress sale, the prices in the secondary market are higher than in the primary market."

Everybody is now carefully planning their strategy. Saffronart's CEO Dinesh Vazirani is looking at a "broader collection to appeal to both older as well as younger collectors", meaning more emerging artists, with lower-value works. Galleries such as Vadehra are extending easy payment options to their clients, even as they continue to hold exhibitions. "It's very important, the signal that you send to the market", says Roshini.

But what is critical, according to Petterson, is what one gleans from this crisis. "Like many other countries, this will provide learnings for India for the second cycle of the market. It will definitely become more self-censoring, self-regulating in the future," he says. Refer to the gloom in the Japanese art market in the early 90s which saw a similar speculative wave of buying. The market only picked up six years later, but served the basis for the next generation. "People will respect higher standards in terms of quality of catalogues, transparency standards etc in the next phase," adds Tuli.

Parekh has another take. "Is the art market impacted more severely than other industries? Probably not. You go into retail, they are offering discounts, you go into a restaurant, they have a new configured menu, so has the art world adapted," she says. The ability of the galleries and connoisseurs to plan is what will paint the future of the Indian art market. ■

“ Buyers will ask more questions around the period, provenance and collection of the artwork rather than being driven simply by the signature. ”

DINESH VAZIRANI, CEO, Saffronart

